First Congregational Church of Los Angeles
Fall Series 11
Sacred Earth, Sacred Soul ~ Sacred Compassion
15 November 2026



The compassion of God is for all that has been made (Psalm 145.9)

Preaching: LVF
Worship Leading: ML & Claire Kelly, Juniper Fayazova, & Garfield Morris

Strips of paper in programs for prayers

Organ Prelude-Concert

Improvisation on BEECHER and LAUDA ANIMA

Aeolian Toccata (Jan Pieterszoon Sweelinck)

Élévation in Eb Major (Auguste Durand)

Pièce de Cornet (Thomas Babou)

Meditation on "Come Ye Thankful People" (Dennis Janzer)

WIR PFLÜGEN (Paul Fejko)

Präludium in C (Carl August Kern)

Prelude on FOREST GREEN (Carlos Staszeski)

Dr. Christoph Bull, *Organist-in-Residence*

Chiming of the Hour

[Michael, Claire, and Youth center chancel]

Welcome **ML**

Words of Gathering **Claire Kelly**
Juniper Fayazova & Garfield Morris

CK: On this day, Holy One, help us to remember
that all things are born of you.

JF: We carry within us your light and your life.
In the mystery of matter
and deep in the cells of our souls
are your longings for oneness.

GM: The oneness of the universe
vast and vibrating with the sound of its beginning.

JF: The oneness of the earth
greening and teeming as a single body.

CK: The oneness of the human soul
a sacred countenance in infinite form.

ALL: ***On this day, grant us your longings for oneness, Holy One,***
amidst life's glorious multiplicities.
[jphilipnewell]

GM: ***Please stand now, in body or in spirit, for our Hymn of Gathering.***

Hymn of Gathering** ***Praise with Joy the World's Creator LAUDA ANIMA
_2021-10-10

- #9 in Pilgrim Hymnal ("Praise, My Soul, the King of Heaven")
- LYRICS (OW)
- PDF
- PRINTED COPIES

Praise with joy the world's Creator, God of justice, love, and peace,
Source and end of human knowledge, grace bestowing without cease.
Celebrate the Maker's glory, power to rescue and release.

Praise to Christ who feeds the hungry, frees the captive, finds the lost,
Heals the sick, upsets religion, fearless both of fate and cost.
Celebrate Christ's constant Presence - Friend and Stranger, Guest and Host.

Praise the Spirit sent among us, liberating truth from pride,
Forging bonds where race or gender, age or nation dare divide.
Celebrate the Spirit's treasure - foolishness none dare deride.

Praise the Maker, Christ, and Spirit, one God in Community,
Calling Christians to embody oneness and diversity.
Thus the world shall yet believe when shown Christ's vibrant unity.

[Michael center chancel]

***Prayer of Awareness** **ML**

Holy One,
as you open our eyes that we might see the needs of others;
open also our ears, that we may hear their cries;
and our hearts so that they need not be without comfort.

Let us not be afraid to defend the weak because of the
anger of the strong,
nor afraid to defend the poor because of the
anger of the rich.
Show us where love and hope and faith are needed,

and use us to bring them to those places.

And then, Holy One, open us with your compassion
so that in the days to come,
we will be able to do the work
of peace with you, and with each other.

May it be so.
May it be so for all of us!
Amen.

***Introit** An Affirmation Andrew Carter
Commonwealth Youth Choir with Cathedral Choir Text: Stephen Grellet
Brandon Harris, *Director of Commonwealth Youth Choir*

I expect to pass through this world but once. Any good thing, therefore, that I can do, or any kindness I can show, or any service I can render to any soul, of human or animal, let me do it now. Let me not defer or neglect it, for I shall not pass this way again.

[Juniper and Garfield to lectern]

***The Lord's Prayer** **Juniper Fayazova & Garfield Morris**

Garfield: Let us now share these words for the Lord's Prayer, adapted from the New Zealand Book of Prayer…

Both:
Eternal Spirit,
Life-Giver, Pain-Bearer, Love-Maker,
Source of all that is and that shall be.
Father and Mother of us all,
Loving God, in whom is heaven:
The hallowing of your name
echo through the universe!
The way of your justice be followed
By all peoples of the world!
Your heavenly will be done
By all created beings!
Your commonwealth of peace and freedom
Sustain our hope and come on earth.

With the bread we need for today, feed us.
In the hurts we absorb from one another, forgive us.
In times of temptation and test, strengthen us.
From trials too great to endure, spare us.
From the grip of all that is evil, free us.

For you reign in the glory of power that is love and grace,

now and forever. Amen.

[All turn towards altar]

***Gloria Deo**
Glory be to God, and to the Christ and to the Holy Ghost,
As it was in the beginning, is now and ever shall be.
World without end, Amen, Amen.

[Michael center chancel]

***Passing of the Peace** **ML**
Hear now these Words of Peace…
Peace in the longing,
peace in the leaving,
peace in the letting go.
In every step, peace.

Today
now
this moment
may we see
the presence of God
in the face of another
and, in our seeing,
may we find life. [adapt/jrichardson]

This morning, may the peace of God be with you.
And also with you!

You are now invited to share this greeting with those near you.

Please be seated

[Claire, Juniper, and Garfield to center chancel]

Reading from the Wisdom of Our Tradition **Claire Kelly**
Juniper Fayazova & Garfield Morris
from the Gospel of Matthew, Chapter 15

CK: Listen with your whole hearts to this reading from the Gospel of Matthew, Chapter 15

GM: After a very long day, Jesus came to the shore of the Sea of Galilee, then went up into the hills. He sat there, and large crowds gathered, bringing with them people who had physical deformities, or couldn't walk, or were blind or deaf, and many others; these they put down at Jesus' feet, and he healed them.

JF: The crowds were astonished as they saw people who had been mute speaking, people who had been deformed whole again, people who had been lame walking about, and people who had been blind seeing. And they gave glory to the God of Israel. Jesus called together the disciples and said, "My heart goes out to all the people. By now they have been with us three days and have nothing to eat. I don't want to send them away hungry—they might collapse on the way home." The disciples said to Jesus, "Where could we get enough food in this deserted place to feed such a crowd?"

CK: Jesus asked, "How many loaves of bread do you have?" "Seven," they replied, "and a few small fish." Then he directed the crowd to sit down on the ground. He took the seven loaves and the fish and gave thanks, then broke them and gave them to the disciples, who gave them to the crowds. All ate until they were full. When they gathered up the leftover fragments, they filled seven baskets. Four thousand families were fed. After Jesus had dismissed the crowd, he got into the boat and sailed to the region of Magadan.

GM: This is the Gospel of Grace.
ALL: ***Thanks be to God!***

[Christoph short transition Michael center chancel]

Prayers with the People **ML**

Invitation to Silence and Prayer
It is in the temple of our inner being,
in the temple of our bodies,
in the temple of earth, sea, and sky,
in the great temple of the universe
that we look for the light that was in the beginning,
the mighty fire that blazes still from the heart of life,
glowing in the whiteness of the moon, glistening in the night stars,
hidden in the black earth, concealed in the unknown depths of our souls.

Often we fail to remember where to look to find ourselves,
and each other.

This morning as we come to this time of silence and meditation
let us remember who we are and with gratitude,
open ourselves to the great compassion of God
that is among us, around us, and within us.

As we share these moments of silence, we are invited to write the prayers of our hearts for our lives and the life of our world on the slips of paper in our programs. If you are online, please share your prayers by emailing prayers@fccla.org.

Then, as the music begins, we are invited to come forward to share our prayers here in the bowl, and to light candles signifying our prayers, for ourselves, those we love and hold dear - and for the life of the world.

Let us now be in silence, together.

Silence

Prayer of Our Hearts
Unfathomable Mystery,
source and substance of all being,
we long to know your presence
in and through our lives.

In our search, we hear you challenge us to work for life that endures,
life that heals the rough and broken places in our lives,
life that takes the pain we carry in our bodies and our hearts,
life that feeds the hunger in ourselves and others for reconciliation.

O God, we are trying to trust
that when we care enough to share ourselves,
there will be enough for all:
enough forgiveness, enough healing, enough compassion.
We hold close to our hearts those we know who are in pain,
and those more distant,
whose lives are heart-wrenching stories in our ears.
O God, together we pray for all those who suffer.

Because of your ever expanding presence,
we continue to be awed by the beauty of your creation.
Our senses overflow with tastes, and smells,
and touch too delicate for words,
and for everyone, who is a precious gift.

We celebrate the rich variety of gifts you offer us in this place,
to build lives with spirituality, community, and justice,
as we work for peace here
and in the many ordinary places of our lives.

This morning, Holy One, hear our prayers of gratitude,
hear our thanks for the richness of the never-ending gifts,
in this marvelous world.

Let us in the days to come,
live our lives as compassionate and generous people,
in all that we do, in all that we are,

and in all we hope to become.

May it be so, O God.
May it be so for all of us.
Amen and Amen.

[Christoph transition for choir]

Meditation Anthem Recovery Family Molly Pease
Molly Pease, *Vocals* text: Randall Pease

Our love Above lip buds bloom as if they're moons. Spirits starring, still eyes shining to pass to others. As if one mother. One wave As cave When wave breaks, beach they seek. Lip buds bloom as if they're moons. Eternal sea. Our womb. Our tomb.

[Christoph transition Laura to pulpit, choir to seats]

Sermon ***Sacred Compassion*** **LVF**

[Christoph transition Michael center chancel]

Invitation to Generosity **ML**

Today, we invite you to support our Community Gardens & Urban Farm here at the Cathedral. These spaces across our 5-acre campus have been intentionally transformed for the growing and sharing of food with our beloved neighbors across Koreatown and Westlake. This food, chosen specifically for the culinary traditions of our neighbors, includes: over 60 fruit trees, a medicinal, culinary, and butterfly garden with herbs for cooking, healing, and struggling Monarch populations, and over 30 raised beds containing varieties of greens and healthy vegetables.

Thank you for joining us in this expansive vision, as we continue to share all that we have and all that we are.

In this time of worship,
here among this gathered people,
we have been given comfort and challenge,
mystery and grace,
to provide for nourishment
each step of our journey.

As people who are truly thankful,
we give from our hearts,
and from our resources to make certain
this place of welcome and belonging
is available for everyone -
whether we come from near or far.

May it be so.

May it be so for all of us!

Offertory Anthem Abendlied Josef Rheinberger
Laude
Stay with us, for the night is almost here and the daylight is almost gone

[All turn towards altar]

***Doxology**
From all that dwell below the skies,
let the Creator's praise arise!
Alleluia! Alleluia!
Your name shall sound and praises soar
till suns shall rise and set no more.
Alleluia! Alleluia!
Alleluia! Alleluia! Alleluia!
[adapt/Isaac Watts, 1719]

[Claire to lectern toward end of doxology]

***Offering Prayer** **Claire Kelly**
Let us pray together:
Thanks be to you, O God,
for the stirrings of new life in us this day,
from rising from the dreams of the night
to a fresh flowing of energy,
for the vitality that awakened our bodies
and the desires that stir our souls.

Let us know the power for life that is in us,
the life-force that is in our senses,
and the might that is within our hearts.

Let us know you as the source of such force
and be wise to its true streams and false currents.

As we leave this sacred time and place,
let us serve love with our strength this day,
let us serve love with our strength.
In heart and mind and body this day,
let us serve love.
[JPhilipNewelladapt/lvf]

May it be so.
May it be so for all of us.
Amen and Amen!

Please be seated

[Laura, Michael, and Claire center chancel]

Life at First Church **ML & CK**

Words of Blessing **LVF**
The blessings of the sun
the blessings of the moon
the blessings of east and west
to guide us on this way
to lighten our eyes
to strengthen our will and our loving.

The blessings of earth
the blessings of air
the blessings of fire and water
to fill us with heaven
to free us with mercy
to stir us with flames of compassion.

May it ever be so.
May it ever be so for all of us!

Choral Response Lean on Me — Bill Withers
Lorenzo Zapata, *Soloist,* Cathedral Choir — arr. Kayo Anderson

Hymn for the Journey** ***Creator of the Intertwined KINGSFOLD
293 - Creator of the Intertwined (KINGSFOLD).pdf

Creator of the intertwined, you made each soul unique:
Each one with ears to hear faith's call, each one with voice to speak.
Each worships where the call is heard in forest, temple, dome,
On mountain-top, in upper room the soul must find its home.

The song of peace best sung by all, strength born of unity.
In harmony we celebrate Your gift: diversity.
Can we not sing each other's songs? Speak unfamiliar prayer?
Rejoicing in the bounty of the differences we share?

In evil's wake we all are hurt; when pricked, all humans bleed.
With common wounds and shared despair, we seek the balm we need.
We do not ask before we reach to offer our embrace,
We do not ask, "How do you pray?": We reach with arms of grace.

Teach us to cherish what is strange and so the richer be,
To listen with our hearts and speak with loving honesty.
From different sources comfort comes, each seeks for the divine:
Your voice speaks many languages, just one of them is mine.

[Michael center chancel]

Postlude

Allegro Maestoso in G Major (Carlos Staszeski)

Dr. Christoph Bull, *Organist-in-Residence*

Inside The Music- Dr. Ianthe Marini
Exploring *Sacred Compassion* we begin with an Affirmation shared between our Youth and Adults through the simple joy of homophonic choral singing: we affirm that any kindness we can render to one another, *let us not defer or neglect it*. In meditation, Molly shares with us her musical setting of the poetry of her late father which, in her words, "deals with his struggles with depression and addiction through oceanic symbolism." Through Molly's sharing we exercise the muscles of compassion as we consider the hardships experienced in ourselves and others, extending grace and kindness to all that we encounter.

In offertory, Laude shares a staple of the choral canon in Rheinberger's *Abendlied,* singing together in easy harmonies and homorhythmic patterns that we will abide with one another as evening or hardship falls. And in choral response, we sing the arrangement of the Bill Withers classic by our friend Kayo Anderson, founder and director of the Peace and Healing Center Los Angeles– ensuring and affirming that through times of struggle and beyond, on one another we can lean. *Just call on me, sibling, when you need a friend: you just might have a problem that I understand! We all need somebody to lean on.*